was ostensibly the decision to tax the traditionally tax-exempt Tokhi tribe that sparked the rebellion, once again the rhetoric of the resistance concentrated on a specifically Islamic set of grievances with the rebels using the language of the jihad and referring to themselves as 'the soldiers of Islam'.[15] Unlike almost all the other British officers in Afghanistan, General Nott was proving a notably effective military commander against the rebels, and developed a quick-moving 5,000–strong anti-insurgency column which could be rapidly deployed in any direction; but as soon as he defeated an uprising in one place, another insurgency flared up elsewhere – thanks, he believed, to the 'hatred in which we are held by the Dooranees as Infidels and Conquerers. Akhtar [Khan Durrani, the leading insurgent in Helmand] describes his party as an "assembly of Muslims and 'ulama" and his cause as the "Glory of Islam". He believes the "Feringees are bent on the destruction and expatriation of the whole Mahomedan population".'[16]

Nott now had as his political assistant the able and clever Henry Rawlinson, the man who had first sighted Vitkevitch heading for the Afghan border four years earlier, and whose epic ride back to Teheran had set off the chain of events which had led to the war. Having recently won the Founder's Medal of the Royal Geographical Society for his explorations in Persia and for his work translating the ancient Persian cuneiform script of the trilingual inscriptions at Behistun, Rawlinson now found himself posted to Kandahar where his job increasingly revolved around translating the calls to holy war being issued almost daily by the ghazis of Kandahar and Helmand. 'All holy men & true believers, the blessing of God be upon you,' began one such document that Rawlinson had forwarded to Macnaghten.

> I have to inform you that the Mussulmans & 'ulema have assembled 5,000 Matchlock-men, Infantry, and 2000 Horsemen fully armed & equipped, and by the blessing of God we will uphold the Glory of Islam – but we must work together & make our arrangements in concert. On receipt of this letter you must collect your own forces & those of the other Ghazis & come & join us. The illustrious Wazir [Yar Mohammad] has written to us from Herat, and please God by the time our forces can unite & march, the Wazir will have reached Girishk & captured it. In raising your followers, do not be idle and place a perfect reliance on our holy cause & march at once to attack the English.[17]

As more and more of these documents began to accumulate from his informers, Rawlinson started to realise for the first time the full scale of the resistance the occupation was now facing. 'I shall be most thankful when you re-enter this town with the 43rd Regiment,' he wrote anxiously to Nott,